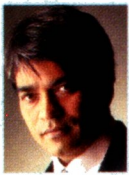


QED SHANKKAR AIYAR

## Truth Involves Us All



Satyameva Jayate may be the credo of India, but in Indian politics, truth is an abstraction of expediency. For validation, switch on the idiot box for a live telecast of the spectacle as politicians interpret truth to suit their political ends. A week, they say, is a long time in politics, but on the street, reality has caught up with India in seven short days. In the name of "national interest", India has been given the short shrift and the voter rendered a mute spectator in the world's largest functioning democracy. In this naked dance for power, icons have exposed their feet of clay.

Once dubbed Mr Integrity, the prime minister finds himself in the company of promiscuous deal-makers. Enemies are friends and friends have turned foes. Visceral hatred has been replaced with declarations of loyalty almost as a tribute to Mario Puzo's famous words in *The Godfather*, "It's not personal, it's just business". The corporatisation of Indian politics has never been so brutally candid. Crony capitalism has given way to capitalism for cronies. The deemed truth for the Congress is that there are no permanent friends or foes, just permanent interests. Conviction is a matter of political convenience and every tool can and will be used to abuse the rule in the book as long as it gets the critical vote. Yesterday's income can be today's disproportionate asset and criminality is contextual.

Across the political fence, id has overwhelmed ideology. The Left, which propounds the moral high ground of political fidelity, is willing to court those once damned communal for vengeance. The BJP, once the party with a difference, finds itself in a piquant situation opposing something it once proposed. Yes, the dispute is in the details of the N-Deal but the opposition is determined by the context of it being the principal Opposition party.

As the two sides battle for their support, fence sitters willing to vote or abstain are laughing their way to new vote banks and cash balances. The UPA may preach national interest but the terms of engagement or endearment, as the case may be, are purely parochial. If one wants a separate state, others want autonomous councils and union territories. The rest would be happy for a place on the gravy train.

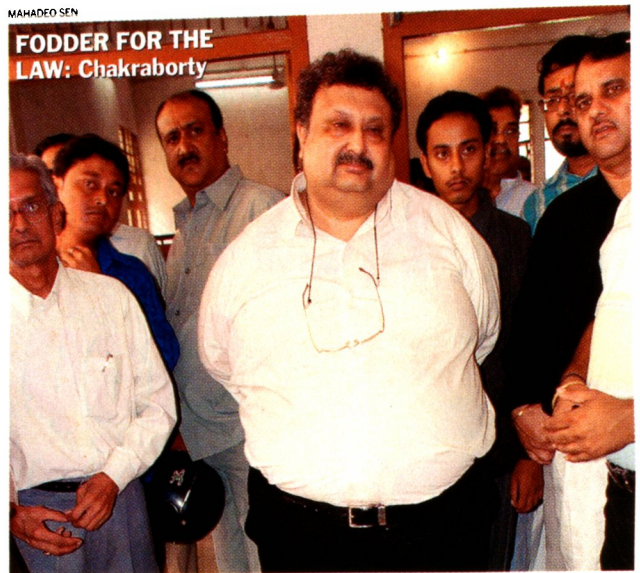
National interest has been reduced to a notion to be determined not by what is good for the nation but who bids the highest at this high-stakes auction. But why blame them politicians alone. We the people may be spectators but must share the blame for choosing expediency over integrity. The truth involves us all.



SAURABH SINGH

MAHADEO SEN

FODDER FOR THE LAW: Chakraborty



## Caught in the Act

**PATNA** Jharkhand Transport Secretary Sajal Chakraborty has now earned the dubious distinction of becoming the first serving IAS officer to be convicted in the infamous Rs 1,000-crore fodder scam. In the 1990s, the Bihar government was swindled when fraudulent allotment bills were cleared from the treasuries.

Chakraborty, a 1980 batch officer, was convicted for sanctioning similar forged bills that facilitated the release of Rs 39 crore from Chaibasa treasury in 1993-94. At that time, he was the deputy commissioner, West Singhbhum district, under undivided Bihar. A case of fraudulent withdrawal of funds was lodged by Chakraborty's successor Amit Khare at Chaibasa on January 27, 1996. Khare is currently principal secretary to Jharkhand Governor Syed Sibtay Razi.

The court also ruled that the charge against Chakraborty that he accepted a laptop from the scamsters in lieu of clear-

ing their bills was established. He was found guilty under eight sections of the IPC and Prevention of Corruption Act.

Incidentally, Chakraborty's conviction came less than a month after former IAS officer Sripati Narain Dubey was awarded four years rigorous imprisonment for sanctioning similar fraudulent withdrawals of Rs 1.47 crore from the Dumka treasury during 1991-92 and 1995-96. Four more retired IAS officers—Beck Julius, M.C. Subarno, Mahesh Prasad and K. Arumugham—are still facing trial in different cases of the fodder scam. Chakraborty is now lodged in Birsamunda Central Jail in Ranchi.

Of the total 59 fodder scam cases registered by the CBI, this was the 28th conviction in as many cases. Fifty-five of these cases were transferred to Jharkhand after the state was carved out of Bihar in 2000, while four are under trial in Bihar.

by Amitabh Srivastava